

SAGITTA

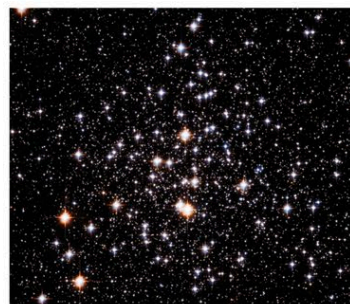
THE ARROW

THE THIRD-SMALLEST CONSTELLATION IN THE SKY, SAGITTA LIES IN THE BAND OF THE MILKY WAY BETWEEN AQUILA AND VULPECULA.

Sagitta is one of the original 48 constellations known to the ancient Greeks. Its four brightest stars, all of 4th magnitude, suggest the shape of an arrow. The main object of interest for users of binoculars or small telescopes is M71. It was long considered to be a rich open cluster but is now classified as a globular cluster, even though it lacks the dense central concentration typical of most globulars. Other notable objects include WZ Sagittae, a dwarf nova star system that undergoes periodic outbursts of energy, and the Necklace Nebula, a planetary nebula with a ring of bright "knots" that resembles a necklace.

▷ M71

This Hubble Space Telescope image shows a brilliant splash of stars in the heart of the globular cluster M71 in Sagitta. M71 lies roughly 13,000 light-years away and is about 27 light-years in diameter.



KEY DATA

Size ranking	86
Brightest stars	Gamma (γ) 3.5, Delta (δ) 3.8
Genitive	Sagittae
Abbreviation	Sge
Highest in sky at 10pm	August
Fully visible	90°N–69°S

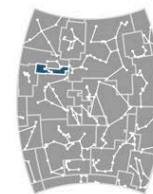


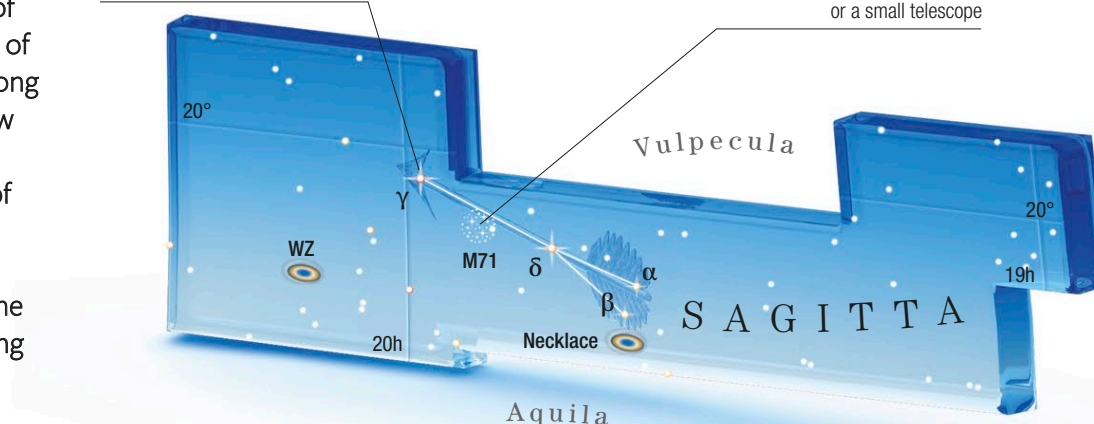
CHART 4

Gamma (γ) Sagittae

A red giant of magnitude 3.5, this is the brightest star in Sagitta. It lies about 258 light-years away

M71

An 8th-magnitude globular cluster near Gamma Sagittae, M71 is visible through binoculars or a small telescope

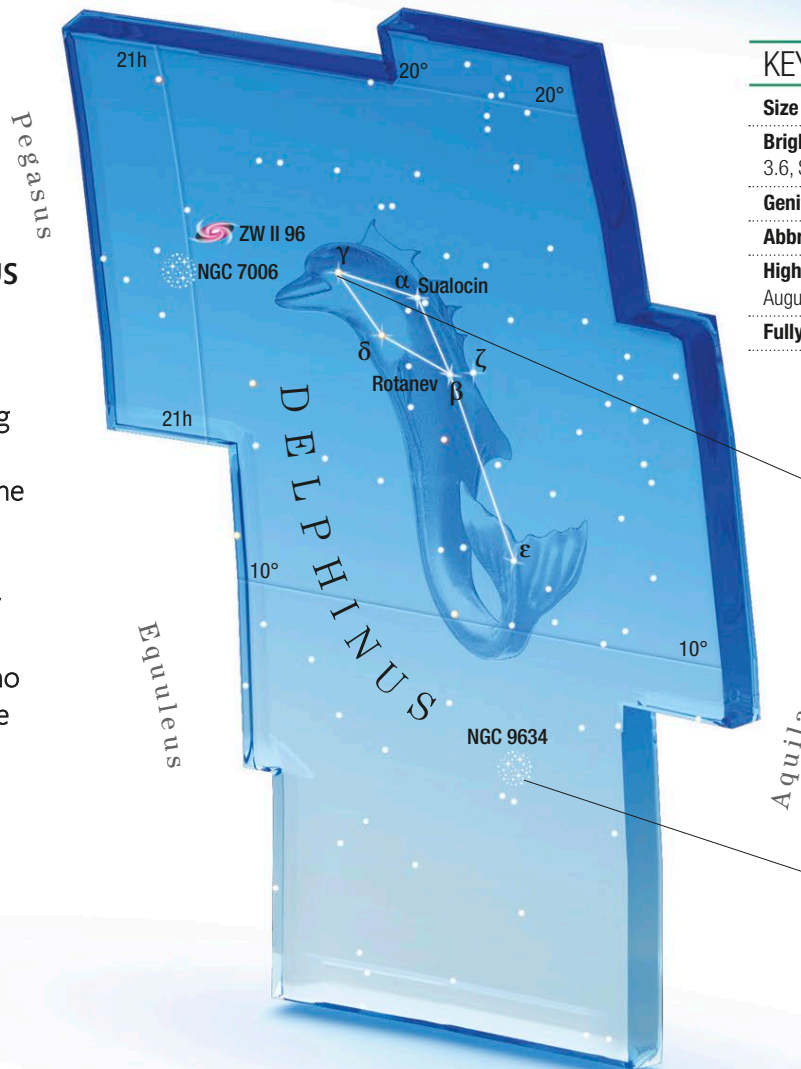


DELPHINUS

THE DOLPHIN

A SMALL NORTHERN CONSTELLATION REPRESENTING A DOLPHIN, DELPHINUS LIES ON THE EDGE OF THE MILKY WAY BETWEEN PEGASUS AND AQUILA.

It is easy to visualize a leaping dolphin among the stars of Delphinus. In Greek mythology, dolphins were the messengers of Poseidon, the sea god. Alpha and Beta Delphini, the constellation's brightest stars, bear the odd names Sualocin and Rotanev. In reverse, they spell Nicolaus Venator, the Latinized form of Niccolò Cacciatore, an Italian astronomer who seemingly named the stars after himself in the early 19th century. Among other objects of interest are Gamma Delphini, a wide double star easily divided with binoculars, the faint globular cluster NGC 6934, and a pair of colliding galaxies known as ZW II 96.



KEY DATA

Size ranking	60
Brightest stars	Rotanev (β) 3.6, Sualocin (α) 3.8
Genitive	Delphini
Abbreviation	Del
Highest in sky at 10pm	August–September
Fully visible	90°N–69°S



CHART 4

Gamma (γ) Delphini

This consists of a wide pair of stars of 5th and 6th magnitudes that can be easily separated through binoculars

NGC 6934

A 9th-magnitude globular cluster about 50,000 light-years away and visible through a small telescope